CONNECT DAILY

Tuesday 27 October 2026
themapsproject.com

A daily scan of national and South Yorkshire developments in education policy, inclusion, SEND, behaviour and accountability — weighted to primary and evidence sources, with links and a clear "so what for your school" line on the items that matter.

Useful? Forward it to a colleague. To join the circulation or partner with the network, get in touch.

TOP LINE

- The big thing to watch this week: Chancellor John Healey delivers his first Budget tomorrow (Wednesday), alongside the OBR's updated economic and fiscal outlook.
- Healey has signalled cost-of-living support will be "targeted and temporary" rather than universal - there's no confirmed steer yet on mainstream or high-needs school funding.
- Otherwise a genuinely quiet half-term week - Sheffield schools are closed until Monday 2 November, and there's no major new national education story in the last day.
- Locally, Sheffield remains one of four finalists for UK City of Culture 2029, alongside Blackpool, Milton Keynes and Wrexham.

DATES FOR THE DIARY

26-30 Oct 2026 — Sheffield schools' autumn half term continues.

28 Oct 2026 — Chancellor John Healey's first Budget, with the OBR's Economic and Fiscal Outlook published alongside it.

15 Dec 2026 — NEU's formal strike ballot over pay, funding and workload closes.

Early 2027 — UK City of Culture 2029 winner announced; Sheffield is one of four finalists.

NATIONAL POLICY & FUNDING

▪ **All eyes on tomorrow's Budget.** Chancellor John Healey delivers his first Budget on Wednesday, with the Office for Budget Responsibility publishing its updated Economic and Fiscal Outlook alongside it. Healey has said living-cost support will be "targeted and temporary" rather than universal; nothing has been confirmed either way yet on further top-ups to mainstream or high-needs school funding, so treat any pre-Budget schools figures circulating this week as speculation until it's delivered. (GB News)

→ **For your school:** *Hold off on budget-planning assumptions until Wednesday's statement and the DfE's response to it are out.*

SHEFFIELD & SOUTH YORKSHIRE

▪ **Sheffield in the final four for City of Culture 2029.** Sheffield is competing with Blackpool, Milton Keynes and Wrexham for the UK City of Culture 2029 title after making the shortlist; all four get at least £125,000 to develop their bids, with £10 million for the eventual winner. Council leader Fran Belbin has pointed to potential benefits for young people's career pathways and aspirations as part of the city's bid. (The Star)

JARGON-BUSTER · OBR

Wednesday's Budget comes with an independent verdict attached.

The Office for Budget Responsibility (OBR) is the UK's independent fiscal watchdog. It publishes an Economic and Fiscal Outlook alongside every Budget, checking the Chancellor's sums against the government's own borrowing and debt rules - its verdict often shapes how much room a Chancellor really has to spend.

MAPS IN PRACTICE – TOOL SPOTLIGHT: SCHOOL+

A strong inclusion strategy is only as good as the cohort picture beneath it.

School+ is the MAPs cohort-vulnerability framework — it maps who your at-risk pupils are and why, giving your inclusion strategy an evidence base rather than a wish list. Explore School+

SOURCES MONITORED

Weighted official- and evidence-first. X is monitored for early signals from official accounts and named commentators, and corroborated against a primary source before anything is included.

Source	Type	What we track
OFFICIAL & STATUTORY		
DfE / GOV.UK	Government	Policy, funding, statutory guidance and statistics
Ofsted	Government	Inspection framework, report cards, annual report
Explore Education Statistics	Government data	Exclusions, suspensions, attendance, census data
House of Commons Library	Parliament	Neutral briefings on bills and policy
RESEARCH & EVIDENCE		
Education Endowment Foundation	Research	Evidence-based guidance, incl. inclusive teaching
NFER	Research	Assessment, workforce, disadvantage
Education Policy Institute	Think tank	Policy analysis and the disadvantage gap
Institute for Fiscal Studies	Think tank	School funding and spending analysis
FFT Education Datalab	Data analysis	Data-driven analysis of attainment and exclusions
INCLUSION & PREVENTION SPECIALISTS		
The Difference	Charity	Whole-school inclusion; "Who's Losing Learning?"
IPPR	Think tank	Lost learning, exclusions, SEND reform
Youth Endowment Fund	Research	What works to prevent youth violence & exclusion
Centre for Social Justice	Think tank	Exclusion tracker and social-mobility policy
Whole School SEND	Network	SEND practice, resources and reviews
SECTOR PRESS & COMMENTARY		
Schools Week	Press	Breaking sector news and investigations
Tes	Press	Practice, policy and workforce
The Guardian (Education)	Press	National coverage and comment
X (monitored)	Social	DfE, Ofsted, EEF and named voices — corroborated before use
LOCAL & REGIONAL		
The Star (Sheffield)	Local press	Local schools and Ofsted outcomes
Sheffield City Council	Local government	Council decisions, funding and local strategy
South Yorkshire MCA & Careers Hub	Regional	Regional skills, careers and funding

Connect Daily is part of Sheffield Connect. Compiled by Andy Marsden, Sector Inclusion Lead.
For circulation across the network and partners. Figures reflect the latest published data at the date of this brief.